

FREE STUDY RESOURCE

Building Biblical Doctrine

A Framework for Drawing Sound Conclusions from Scripture

A practical guide for defining a doctrinal question, collecting relevant Scripture, respecting context and audience, organizing evidence, and stating a conclusion with appropriate care.

PURPOSE

Use this resource to organize your study. Use the Biblical Hermeneutics Course to develop the complete interpretive skill required to carry out each step responsibly and independently.

How This Resource Helps You

This resource helps you move beyond collecting isolated verses and toward building doctrinal conclusions that account for context, audience, progressive revelation, and divine program. It provides a disciplined structure for organizing biblical evidence, identifying the strength of each claim, recognizing unresolved questions, and stating conclusions with appropriate care.

- Define a doctrinal question precisely before beginning research.
- Keep the meaning, audience, and assignment of each passage visible.
- Compare supporting and challenging evidence without erasing biblical distinctions.
- Match the certainty of the final statement to the strength of the evidence.

How to Use This Resource

1. **Begin with one question.** Write one clearly defined doctrinal question that Scripture can answer.
2. **Read every major passage in context.** Examine the surrounding paragraph, section, book, historical setting, and stated purpose.
3. **Complete a Doctrine Evidence Record.** Use one record for each controlling passage before combining the evidence.
4. **Identify audience and assignment.** Record the speaker or writer, original audience, revelatory setting, and program or assignment.
5. **Compare the complete evidence set.** Use the Doctrinal Synthesis Worksheet to organize agreement, complementary emphasis, different assignments, and unresolved tensions.
6. **Record challenging evidence.** Do not omit passages that appear to question or qualify the proposed conclusion.
7. **Classify the conclusion.** Determine whether it is explicit teaching, necessary inference, reasonable inference, or unresolved.
8. **Write a qualified doctrinal statement.** State only what the combined evidence warrants and include necessary limitations.
9. **Test and revise.** Return to the passages and revise the conclusion if it fails to account for the complete evidence set.

What Biblical Doctrine Requires

Biblical doctrine is a carefully stated conclusion about what Scripture teaches. It is not created by collecting phrases that appear to support an idea. Sound doctrine begins with the meaning of each passage in its own setting and then brings the relevant evidence together without erasing distinctions established in the text.

The controlling order is simple: meaning first, assignment second, application third. A passage must be understood before its audience or programmatic assignment is determined, and both must be established before a present application is claimed.

Three Levels to Keep Distinct

Level	Central Question	Result
Interpretation	What does this passage communicate in its context?	The meaning of the passage
Synthesis	How does this passage relate to the other relevant evidence?	An organized body of findings
Doctrine	What conclusion is warranted by the combined evidence?	A clear, qualified doctrinal statement

Foundational Controls

- Context controls meaning. Read the paragraph, section, book, historical setting, and stated purpose.
- Audience and assignment matter. Do not transfer promises, commands, offices, signs, or expectations merely because they appear in Scripture.
- Progressive revelation must be respected. Later revelation may disclose truth previously hidden without making earlier revelation say what had not yet been revealed.
- Israel and the Body of Christ remain distinct. During Acts 9–28, Prophecy and Mystery operate concurrently; their overlap must not be treated as the erasure of either program.
- The Mystery begins in Acts 9, is revealed through Paul, operates during the overlap, and continues beyond Acts 28. Prophecy begins before Acts 9 and is suspended at Acts 28.

The Doctrine Building Framework

The following framework is a study map, not a substitute for complete hermeneutical training. Work slowly. Record the evidence that challenges an initial conclusion as carefully as the evidence that appears to support it.

10. **Define the question precisely.** State one doctrinal question that can be answered from Scripture. Avoid broad or emotionally loaded wording.
11. **Collect the relevant passages.** Begin with passages that directly address the subject, then include passages that supply necessary historical, audience, or programmatic context.
12. **Interpret each passage in context.** Record what the passage communicates before deciding how it contributes to the final doctrine.
13. **Classify the evidence.** Identify the speaker or writer, original audience, setting, covenant or program, time in revelation, and kind of evidence supplied.
14. **Compare without collapsing distinctions.** Look for agreement, complementary emphasis, different assignments, and apparent tensions that require further study.
15. **State only what the evidence warrants.** Distinguish explicit teaching, necessary inference, reasonable inference, and speculation.
16. **Test and qualify the conclusion.** Ask whether the conclusion accounts for all major passages and whether its certainty matches the strength of the evidence.

Evidence Strength

Classification	How to Use It
Explicit teaching	The passage directly teaches the point in its context.
Necessary inference	The conclusion follows from the evidence and is required for the passages to remain coherent.
Reasonable inference	The conclusion fits the evidence but is not the only possible explanation.
Speculation	The conclusion goes beyond what the available evidence can establish.

Doctrine Evidence Record

Complete one record for each major passage. Add pages as necessary. The purpose is to preserve the passage's meaning and setting before it is used in a larger doctrinal conclusion.

Doctrinal question	
Passage	
Immediate context	
Speaker or writer	
Original audience	
Historical and revelatory setting	
Program or assignment	
What the passage explicitly teaches	
What the passage does not establish by itself	
Relationship to other evidence	

Doctrinal Synthesis Worksheet

After the major passages have been interpreted and recorded, use this page to organize the combined evidence. If a tension remains unresolved, record it rather than forcing a premature conclusion.

1. State the doctrinal question in one sentence.
2. List the passages that teach the subject most directly.
3. Summarize the central teaching shared by the evidence.
4. Record important audience, covenant, program, or revelatory distinctions.
5. Identify passages that appear to challenge the proposed conclusion.
6. Explain whether the passages agree, complement one another, address different assignments, or require additional study.
7. Classify the conclusion: explicit teaching, necessary inference, reasonable inference, or unresolved.
8. Write the doctrinal conclusion with any necessary qualifications.

Common Doctrine Building Errors

Error	Why It Weakens the Conclusion
Beginning with a conclusion	The student searches for supporting phrases instead of allowing the evidence to define and refine the conclusion.
Using an isolated verse	A sentence is detached from its paragraph, argument, audience, or historical setting.
Treating every passage as directly addressed to the same audience	Meaning, assignment, and application are collapsed into one category.
Ignoring progressive revelation	Later truth is read backward into an earlier setting where it had not yet been revealed.
Erasing the Acts overlap	Prophecy and Mystery are treated as though one instantly replaced the other, rather than operating concurrently during Acts 9–28.
Equating repetition with proof	Several dependent or parallel references are counted as though they were independent lines of evidence.
Overstating certainty	A reasonable inference is presented as explicit teaching, or speculation is presented as settled doctrine.
Avoiding contrary evidence	Difficult passages are ignored instead of being interpreted, classified, and incorporated honestly.

Final Review Questions

- Have I interpreted the major passages before combining them?
- Have I identified the audience and assignment of each passage?
- Have I preserved the distinction between Israel and the Body of Christ?
- Does my conclusion explain the difficult evidence as well as the familiar evidence?
- Is my wording more certain than the evidence allows?

From Framework to Competency

This resource helps you organize a doctrinal investigation. It cannot by itself supply the interpretive judgment required to resolve every contextual, grammatical, historical, canonical, or programmatic question. Those abilities develop through sustained instruction and repeated practice.

The Biblical Hermeneutics Course provides that complete training. Its forty-lesson sequence develops the student from foundational interpretation through discovery, synthesis, diagnostic analysis, responsible application, guided integration, and independent study. The course explains why the controls in this resource matter and trains the student to use them with increasing accuracy.

Use This Resource When You Need To

- frame a doctrinal question before beginning research;
- record the context and assignment of major passages;
- compare evidence without erasing biblical distinctions;
- identify where a conclusion is explicit, inferred, or unresolved;
- prepare findings for further study, teaching, or review.

Use the Complete Course When You Need To

- learn the full interpretive method behind these steps;
- work through competing interpretations and difficult passages;
- develop discovery and synthesis skills across biblical programs;
- practice diagnostic hermeneutics and responsible application;
- progress toward independent, accountable interpretation.

NEXT STEP

Explore The Biblical Hermeneutics Course to build a complete interpretive method and learn to apply it responsibly.